

There are many third-party software that protect your system better than does the Firewall that comes bundled with XP: third-party firewalls have good and easy-to-understand interfaces that allow you to configure your Firewall as though you were a pro. Some Firewalls come bundled with other utilities such as stoppers, anti-virus, and anti-spyware.

Let's take Zone Alarm Pro (www.zonelabs.com) as an example; the software, after installation, takes you through a series of presentations telling how to configure the Firewall. It also allows you to configure it before it starts for the first time. When you are connected to the Internet and an application is trying to access the Net, Zone Alarm asks you if you want to allow the program to allow access. The Firewall also protects your system over a home network.

Other good Firewalls are Symantec Security Suite and Trend Micro PC-Cillin.

10.4 Updates And Patches

Updates are small changes to a program. They may be an update to any part of the system software, and the update is always regarded as better than the previous version. An update can either change the functionality of the original software in certain respects, or it may include additional features that were previously not present. An update may be denoted as a change in the last digit of a version number (such as version 3.0 to 3.1).

A patch is an update meant to fix problems. This can range from fixing bugs to replacing graphics to improving the usability or performance of a previous version. Though meant to fix problems, patches can sometimes introduce new problems too! The size of a patch file varies in size; some might be a few KB, and others might run into hundreds of MBs. Often, a collection of patches are bundled together and are called service packs.